

U.S. Streaming Subscription Pricing Analysis, 2018-2026

What U.S. streaming prices have actually done since 2018, and whether ad tiers and bundles are absorbing it

11.2%

flagship price CAGR, 2022-26

3.0x

the rate of CPI, same window

+48%

mean real increase (median +27%)

67

sourced price points, 8 services

A maturing market turns to price

Subscriber growth has flattened, so price and packaging are the levers left. Two questions follow.

3.0x

Flagship no-ad prices compounded at roughly three times CPI over 2022–2026, the window in which all eight services were in market.

11.2% a year vs. CPI at 3.7%

Question one: is it real?

- A decade of high inflation sits inside that number
- Deflating by CPI-U tests how much survives
- And whether the increase is category-wide or concentrated

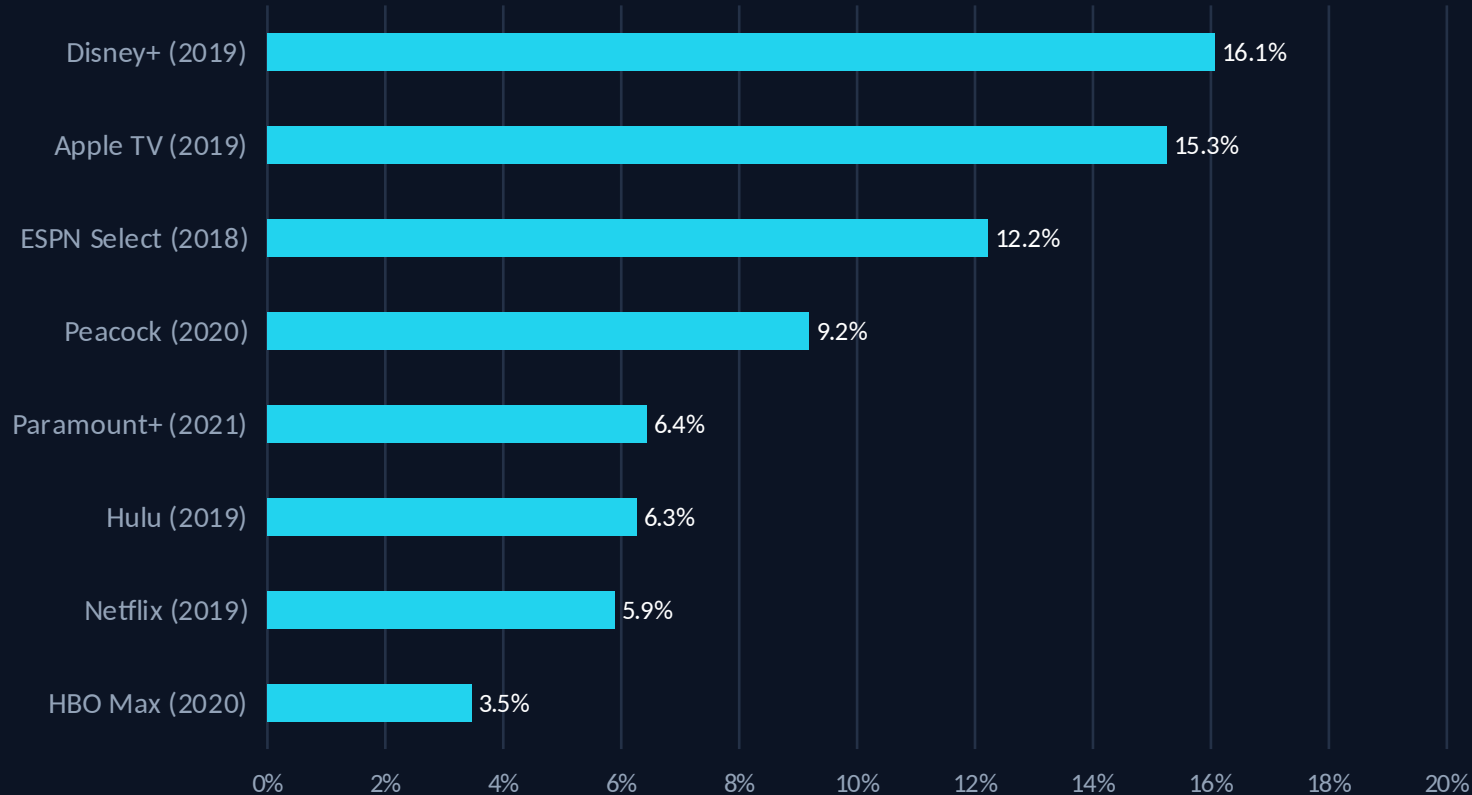
Question two: do the valves work?

- The ad tier is assumed to hold a cheap entry point
- Bundles are assumed to blunt any single app's price
- Both assumptions are testable against list prices

THE PATTERN

Every flagship tier has risen. The rates are not close.

Compound annual growth in the ad-free flagship tier, measured from each service's own launch.



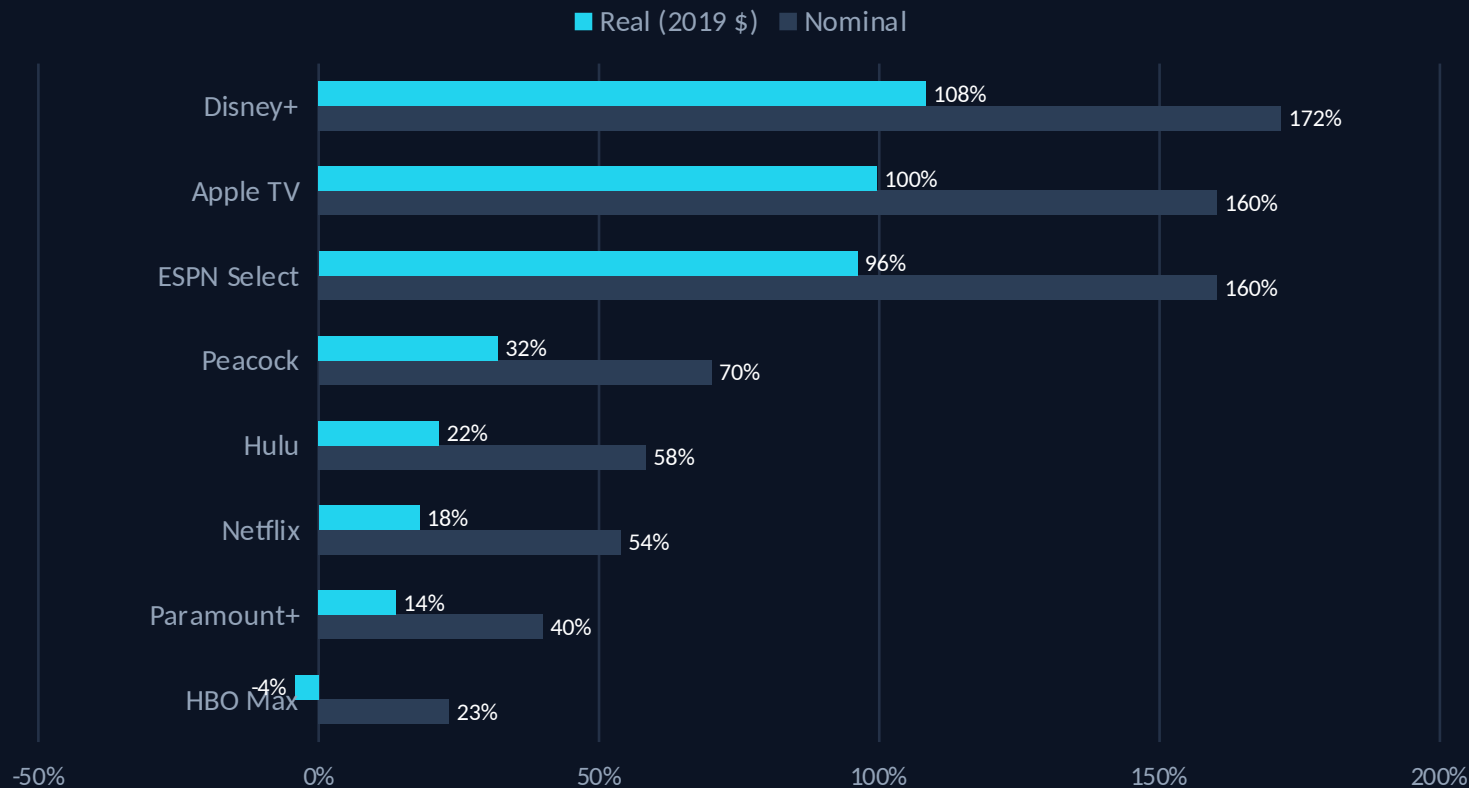
16.1% Disney+ compounded fastest, climbing off a \$6.99 launch price set well below the category.

3.5% HBO Max rose slowest. It launched at the category ceiling and had nowhere to go.

One caveat. Windows differ, from 5.4 to 8.3 years, so this ranks each service on its own history rather than head to head. Mean 9.3%, median 7.8%, range 3.5 to 16.1%.

Strip out inflation and the story concentrates

Each launch price is deflated by the CPI-U index of the year it took effect, then compared in constant 2019 dollars.



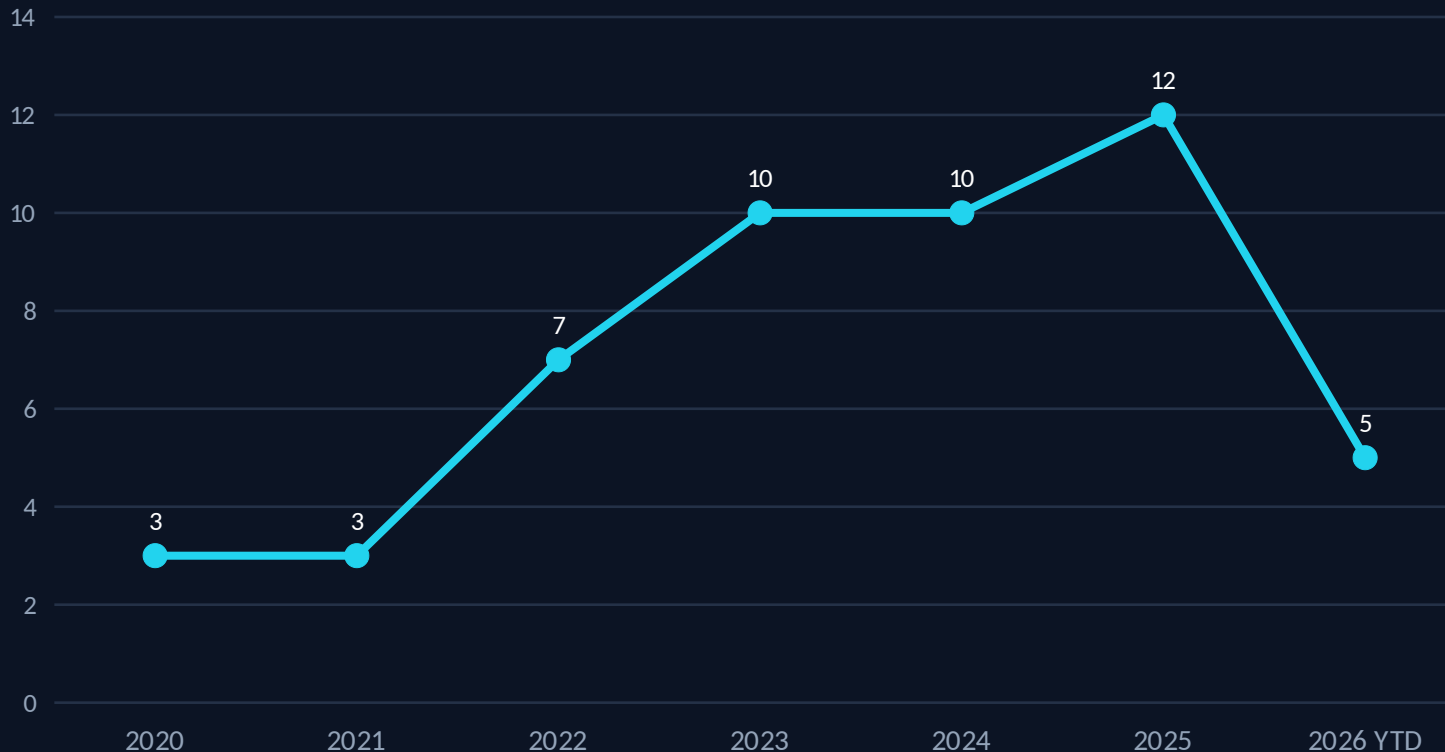
Real, but concentrated

- About half the headline increase survives deflation, so this is not just CPI drift.
- Three services carry it: Disney+ (+108%), Apple TV (+100%), ESPN Select (+96%).
- HBO Max is down 4% in real terms and Paramount+ up 14%. Those two raised in name more than in substance.
- Mean +48%, median +27%. The gap between those two numbers says more than either one does.

AND IT'S ACCELERATING

Price changes have gone from occasional to routine

Documented list-price changes across all 17 tracked tiers, by calendar year.



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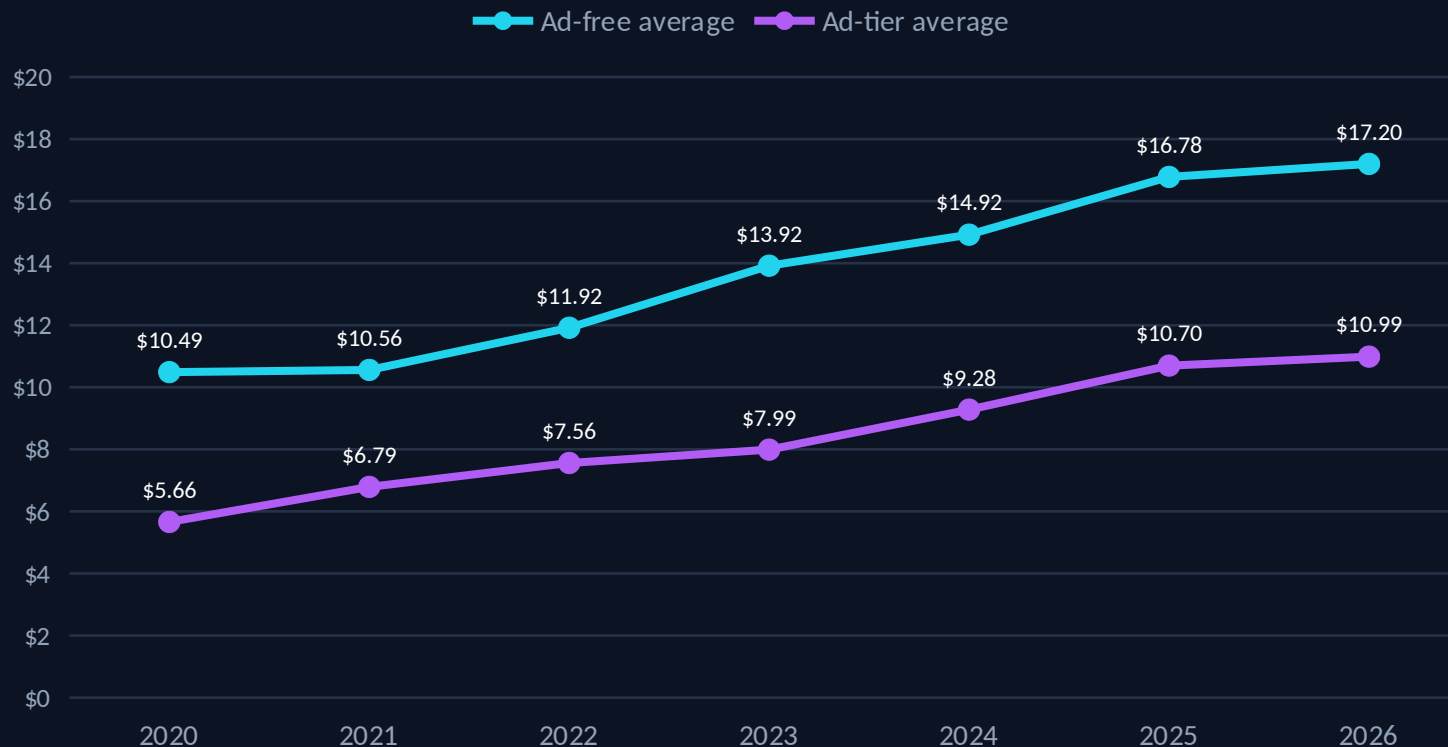
documented price changes in 2025, four times the 2020 rate.

2026 is only seven months long.

Five changes through July annualizes to roughly nine, putting 2026 in line with 2025. The dip at the right edge is a partial year, not a slowdown.

The ad tier is not holding the line

Category-average price by tier type, computed from the price panel at each year-end.

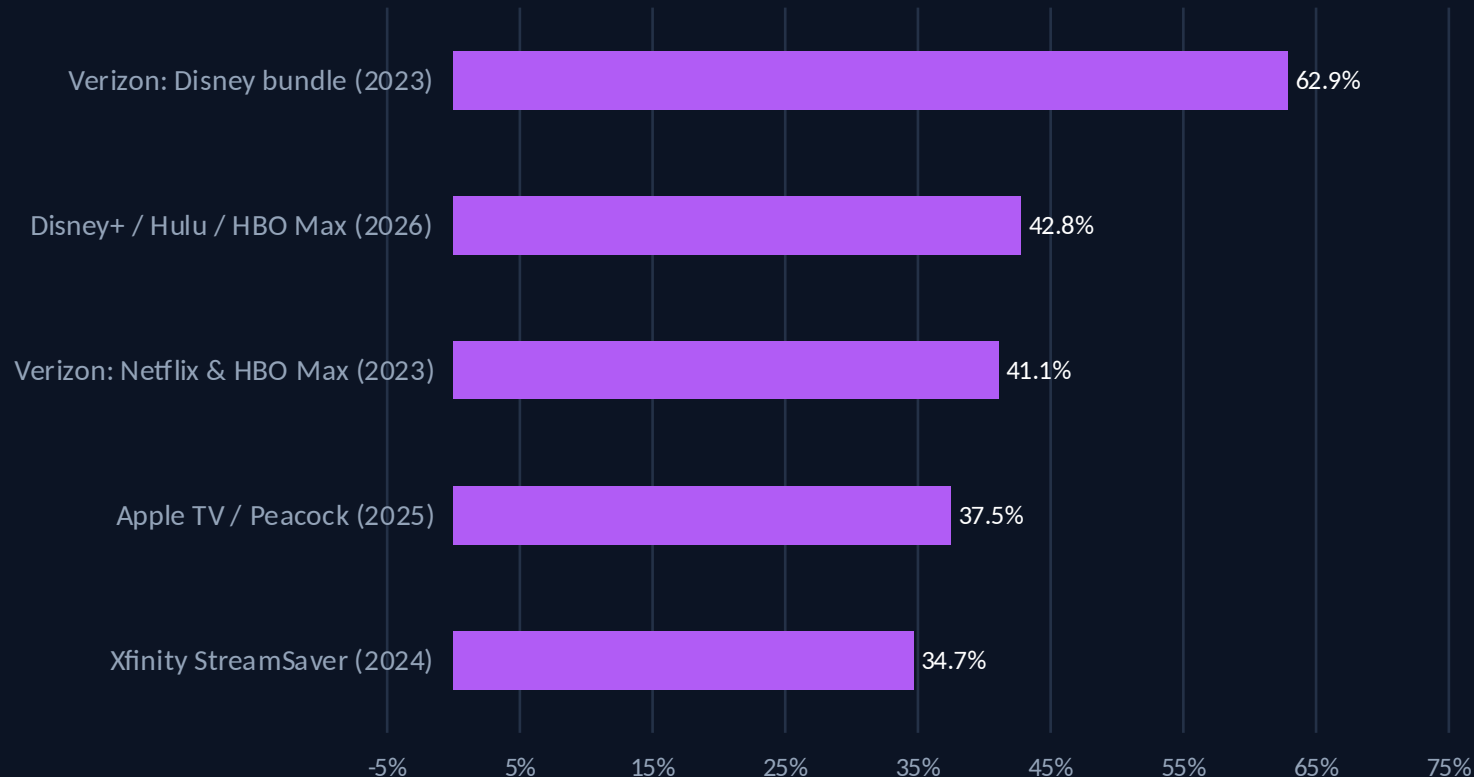


The assumption doesn't hold

- Since end-2022 the ad tier is up 45% against 44% for ad-free. The cheap plan rose faster.
- The implied discount has been flat near 36% for four years.
- The entry point itself has nearly doubled, from \$5.66 in 2020 to \$10.99.
- If ads help retention, the mechanism is the second revenue stream, not a widening price gap.

Bundles discount hard, so list price drifts from what people pay

Bundle price vs. the sum of component standalone prices, both measured at the same date.



Three archetypes

- Telecom perk: the carrier is buying retention on its own subscription, so it discounts deepest.
- Cable distributor: Xfinity re-aggregates for a base it already has.
- Streamer-to-streamer: rivals partner directly, at the shallowest discount.
- Median 41%, range 35 to 63%. Telecom perks average 52% against 38% for streamer and distributor deals. These are different products, not one market.

Every finding here has the same ceiling

Price is the strongest public signal left in this category. It is also a shrinking share of what matters.

What is disappearing

- Netflix stopped reporting subscribers and ARPU after Q4 2024.
- Disney is winding down subscriber disclosure. Apple and Amazon never started.
- Bundles now run 35 to 63% off standalone, so list price and realized price are diverging.
- Definitions differ by company, so what remains is not comparable across services.

What it means commercially

- Two things are happening at once: the public record is thinning and published price is drifting from what people actually pay.
- Both trends raise the value of measuring behavior directly rather than inferring it from filings.
- That is the condition this analysis kept running into, on every tab.

THE QUESTION THIS RAISES

2025 was the heaviest pricing year on record. Churn stabilized anyway.

Putting this price panel next to Antenna's published category data produces a question neither dataset answers alone.

This analysis

12

documented list-price changes in 2025, four times the 2020 rate and the most in the panel.

The ad-free category average rose 12.4% in that single year, from \$14.92 to \$16.78.

Antenna, Q1'26 report

4.6%

weighted average Premium SVOD churn in 2025, described as a steady rate after years of volatility.

Churn was flat or lower in 7 of 11 months to August 2025, against 2 of the previous 21.

So which is it?

- Prices rose harder than in any prior year and retention held. Three explanations fit.
- The valves absorbed it: subscribers moved down a tier or into a bundle rather than out.
- Or demand is less elastic than the pricing implies, and there was headroom all along.
- Or list price is not what people paid: Antenna notes 2025 growth clustered around Q4 promotions and programming events.

List prices cannot separate these. Behavioral panel data can.

Each finding, and the metric that would settle it

What I would want to look at first if I had subscriber-level data behind this pricing panel.

The ad tier rose faster than ad-free and the discount held flat near 36%.



Gross adds by tier around each increase, and Ad Manager share. If ad-tier acquisition kept climbing while the discount narrowed, price was not what drove the tier choice.

Twelve price changes in 2025, with category churn steady.



Gross churn against net churn in the 90 days after each change. A downgrade and a cancel-then-resubscribe look identical in gross churn and very different in revenue.

Bundles discount 35 to 63% against standalone.



Tenure and resubscribe rate for bundle-acquired subscribers versus direct. Whether the discount buys durable subscribers or cheap ones.

Disney+, Apple TV and ESPN captured nearly all the real price growth.



Whether the services with the most demonstrated pricing power also carry the lowest serial-churner exposure, or whether they are simply raising on a base that cannot leave.

None of this is answerable from public data, which is exactly why it is the interesting part.

WHERE THIS GOES NEXT

Pricing became continuous. Measurement has to follow.

01 Price is now a routine lever

Twelve changes in 2025 against three in 2020. Pricing has moved from an annual event to a continuous operating decision, which means its effects have to be tracked continuously too.

02 Tier mix is the revenue question

With the ad-free and ad-supported tiers converging in price, what matters is no longer the discount but which tier subscribers actually sit in, and how often they move.

03 List price is drifting from realized price

At a third to two thirds off standalone, bundles have made the published number a weaker proxy every year. Two of the three inputs to revenue are now unobservable from outside.

04 So the scarce input is behavior

Public disclosure is thinning at the same time published price is losing meaning. What is left is measuring what subscribers do, which is the market this analysis kept running into the edge of.